Copenhagen Climate Change Conference, it was together with its BASIC partners that China had negotiated the Copenhagen Accord with the US. This reflects how, in just about six years, China gained greater confidence in the years following the global financial and economic crisis and began to see itself in the same power league as the US. It no longer had any reason to benchmark itself with other large emerging economies like India.

China has traditionally thought of power in hierarchical terms. The nature of its relations with a country or group of countries is determined by the category in which it has placed the latter. In 2010, China introduced the concept of 'new type of great power relations' to describe its relations with the US in the aftermath of the global financial and economic crisis of 2008. [4] In May that year, at the second Sino-U.S. Strategic and Economic Dialogue, Chinese State Councilor Dai Bingguo said:

> China and the US should initiate an era of globalization with a new type of great power relations of mutual respect, harmonious coexistence, and win-win by states with different social systems, cultural traditions, and levels of development. [5]

In his meeting with US President Obama in June 2013, Chinese President Xi Jinping elaborated the concept further, stating that it consisted of three elements: one, neither confrontation nor conflict; two, mutual respect; and three, win-win cooperation.

China was now placing itself in the front rank with the US, with neighbouring and developing countries ranked below, and with multilateral institutions following last. The corollary to this ranking in hierarchical terms implies that the countries concerned must order their relations with China in accordance with the rank which has been ascribed to them by China. If China considers itself to now belong to the 'great power' category, it expects the deference due to it in that capacity. This is reflected in its behaviour even in the groupings that were originally conceived as representing the large emerging economies. Currently, in each of these groupings, like the BRICS and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO), China is clearly the dominant partner.

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